

Town of Westhampton
Town Hall
1 South Road
Westhampton, MA 01027

Finance Committee Meeting Minutes
Tuesday, March 18, 2014

The meeting convened at 6:45 PM

Present:

Finance Committee Members: Ellice Gonzalez, Jackie Brodeur, Mary Cleary, Aniko Giordano, Margaret Parsons, Joe Pipczynski, Celeste Whiting, Ed Zawacki.

Additional Attendees: Cheryl Provost, Administrative Assistant; Dean Bates, Elementary School Principal; Cindy Landers, Business Administrator; Jaimee Roncone, School Committee; and Bobby Jones.

1. Cheryl reviewed the papers presented to the Finance Committee and noted that the Finance Committee is tasked with voting on a counsel fees transfer, Highway Department transfer and a vote on overspending for snow removal.
2. Elementary Budget: The committee reviewed the revised Elementary School Budget that we received by email on March 17. Dean Bates reviewed the reasons for the significant proposed budget increase. He explained that this year there are fewer school choice spots available (so revenue is not available), that there is an increase in mandated SPED spending, and the teachers' and transportation contracts are up for renewal this year.

The Finance Committee raised several questions about the proposed budget and questions were answered by Cindy Landers and Dean Bates. Discussion and questions as follows:

The Finance Committee inquired about the line item regarding the SPED teacher salary changing from FY14 \$97,341 to FY15 \$29,938. Cindy Landers noted that this is due in part to a teacher retiring and the plan to hire a teacher at a lower pay bracket, but mostly due to the offset of the school choice revolving funds of \$61,867.

Cindy noted a correction in the SPED aides line on page 2. The FY2014 Expended and Encumbered line reads \$39,490 and it should read \$81,000.

Cindy explained that the school library budget is listed as zero because the town receives a REAP grant to offset those costs.

Dean Bates noted that the Contract Services on page 2 reflect the fee for the Curtis Blake school services.

Discussion of the renewal of the bus contract. Cindy noted that the bus contractor had previously underbid the contract and, coupled with increase fuel costs, they are anticipating a increase of approximately \$10,000. The town currently contracts with Durham. The town requires the running of three vehicles for bus transportation due to road and bridge conditions on the Reservoir Road Extension and King's Highway. The bid deadline is April 1st, so we will have the information before Town Meeting.

We noted that the buildings line item was increased from \$16,863 to \$28,250. Cindy explained that this is due to boiler repairs (approx. \$5,800) and rubbish disposal (approx. \$800).

Margie noted that with the corrections there is approximately \$75,000 of this year's budget that is not yet expended or encumbered. Cindy explained that some contracts are not paid until the end of the year.

Ellice requested that Cindy and Dean provide as much detail and as possible in the forthcoming corrected/updated budget so that the Finance Committee will be able to vote on the matter.

3. Town Budget: We received a revised town budget with updated numbers from the Tax Collector, Highway Department and the Library (see attached department budgets and attached revised town budget). Due to time limitations we did not review these department budgets during the meeting.

4. Reviewed and accepted minutes from the March 4, 2014 meeting. Vote 8-0-0.

5. Reviewed correspondence. Celeste gets a copy of the Beacon.

6. New Business: Three votes

The Finance Committee voted 8-0-0 to allow for overspending of the snow removal budget as per Massachusetts General Law Chapter 44, 31 D (see attached).

The Finance Committee voted 8-0-0 to transfer \$500 from the Reserve Fund to Road Machinery to pay for the insurance deductible required after filing an accident claim.

The Finance Committee discussed the request for \$10,600 from the Reserve Fund to Counsel Fees. We noted that this would effectively drain the Reserve Fund and since we are meeting weekly, if more funds are needed we can vote in the subsequent weeks.

The Finance Committee voted 8-0-0 to transfer \$2,000 from the Reserve Fund to Counsel Fees.

7. Upcoming Events:

There will be a Town Caucus on April 14th. Maryanne, Mary and Joe must attend as their terms required renomination to the Finance Committee. We also noted that there is one vacant spot on the Finance Committee. It would be nice to fill it.

There will be a program on Sunday, March 30 from 2-4 pm at the library honoring EMTs.

The Hampshire Municipal Conference will be on April 12th. Several FinCom members will attend.

We will meet again on March 25th at 6:45 pm.

Respectfully Submitted by Mary Cleary